

SIKHYA Chandigarh

CONSCIENCE CALL

A Class IX student, Shabnam resides in Chandigarh's colony No. 5, which is a cluster of squalid shanties. Many electricity connections here are unauthorised. The local authorities regularly label water in the hand-pump as "not potable", but she still drinks it. Life may not be perfect for Shabnam but the hours between 8 a.m. and 3 p.m. are different. That's when she is in her school, Sikhya. Run by the Guru Nanak Vidya Bhandar Trust, the school was set up three years back by 72-year-old industrialist Gurpreet Singh "answering grandfather SBS Dharam's call to educate the poor". Children might be used to speaking and listening to abuses in their slums, but here they converse in English. Just in case you spot students gnawing on biscuits like rats, make no mistake. They are trying to make rectangles and squares out of them. The school believes undeserving students should fail, so that they learn about failures at an age when they can take it. No wonder, in a comparative study of schools, experts from the Government Home Science College found Sikhya's students "exhibit higher levels of resilience, civil engagement and adaptability". Sikhya has 780 students and was set up in 2006 at a cost of Rs 12 crore with an annual budget of Rs 1.6 crore. "To ensure there is no let up in funds, the owners have dedicated some of their buildings to each of their institutes. The rents from those come to us," says Principal Sonia Channi, 48. It's still too new an institute for anyone to assess its impact, but it looks set to go a long way. *by Arvind Chhabra*

VIKRAM SHARMA



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PUBLIC HEALTH FOUNDATION OF INDIA Across the Country

LIVING EXAMPLE



REUBEN SINGH

The National Rural Health Mission requires 700 trained epidemiologists and India has only 100. It requires 10,500 public health managers. Again there is a gap. It's precisely this that the Public Health Foundation of India (PHFI), set up in 2006, intends to fill. With tripartite funding from the government, the Bill and Melinda Gates Foundation and individuals such as Rohini Nilekani and Shiv Nadar in India, as well as Vinod Khosla and Desh Deshpande in the US, and a corpus of Rs 230 crore, it is currently running six diploma courses in various aspects of public health from rented campuses in Gurgaon, Hyderabad and Gandhinagar which are open to students with non-medical backgrounds. With land clearance nearly complete, the PHFI hopes to have the

buildings ready in 18 months. The idea originated when Rajat Gupta, former managing director, McKinsey, was approached by public health schools in the US to set up an equivalent of the Indian School of Business in public health. Dr K. Srinath Reddy, 58, who has been with All India Institute of Medical Sciences in Delhi since 1974 when he was a junior resident in cardiology, and is a leading advocate in the anti-tobacco campaign, is the president. It's his vision of sending faculty to be trained abroad at partner schools and undertaking global research projects to raise funds that is guiding PHFI, which seems to be a perfect example of private-public partnership with various state governments showing immense interest in the creation of a public health cadre. *by Kaveree Bamzai*

5 million pounds is the amount given by the Wellcome Trust to train 76 faculty members for MPH over the next five years at 12 public health schools in the UK.